

A Golden Coral So Strange It Got Its Own New Family

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Deep in the Pacific Ocean near Costa Rica, scientists found a bright yellow **coral** that does not fit into any known **coral** family. So they made a brand-new family for it!

The **coral** grows in branches that look like trees. Some are more than a meter tall, which is over 3 feet. It lives between 360 and 529 meters deep, on underwater mountains called **seamounts**. Scientists used an underwater robot named SuBastian to collect samples.

The **coral** grows among **brittle stars**, which are relatives of starfish. The yellow branches looked like glowing trees surrounded by stars.

That gave scientists an idea for its name. They used Elvish, a language made up by J.R.R. Tolkien, who wrote "The Lord of the Rings." The name Laurinque means "golden tree," and elenya means "of the stars."

Scientists studied hundreds of the **coral's genes** to learn where it belongs. The discovery shows how much of the deep ocean is still unexplored.

Word Treasure

coral -- An ocean animal that often grows in shapes like trees or rocks.

seamounts -- Mountains under the ocean.

brittle stars -- Sea animals related to starfish.

genes -- Tiny instructions inside living things that shape how they grow.

Background you need

Corals are animals, and some of them live deep in the dark ocean.

Scientists put living things into groups called families based on how closely related they are, often by studying their genes.

Break it down

WHO: Ocean scientists studying the deep sea

WHAT: They found a bright yellow coral so different that it needed a new family

WHERE: Underwater mountains in the Pacific Ocean near Costa Rica

WHY: Its genes showed it did not match any known coral family

Why it matters

It shows there are still amazing animals waiting to be discovered in the deep ocean.

Test what you remember

1. What color is the new coral?

- ☐ (A) Bright yellow
- ☐ (B) Black
- ☐ (C) Purple
- ☐ (D) Blue

2. Near which country was it found?

- ☐ (A) Egypt
- ☐ (B) Canada
- ☐ (C) Costa Rica
- ☐ (D) Japan

3. What do the coral's branches look like?

- ☐ (A) Rocks
- ☐ (B) Flowers
- ☐ (C) Fish
- ☐ (D) Trees

4. What is the name of the underwater robot?

- ☐ (A) Elenya
- ☐ (B) SuBastian
- ☐ (C) Laurinque
- ☐ (D) Falkor

5. What does Laurinque mean?

- ☐ (A) Deep sea
- ☐ (B) Of the stars
- ☐ (C) Golden tree
- ☐ (D) Yellow rock

6. Who made up the Elvish language used in the name?

- ☐ (A) Charles Darwin
- ☐ (B) J.R.R. Tolkien
- ☐ (C) A Costa Rican fisherman
- ☐ (D) A NASA scientist

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: C 3: D 4: B 5: C 6: B

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):